



Exchange of Food Benefits & Replacement of Formula

Policy: Unredeemed food benefits may be exchanged for any participant for current or future months. Participants switching to a different formula may have their benefits exchanged. Formula can be replaced in certain emergency situations.

Regulation: 7 CRF 246.12, 7 CRF 246.10, USDA WIC Food Package Guidance

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

Exchanging Non-Formula Food Benefits

- Non-formula food packages may only be exchanged if no food items have been redeemed.

Unredeemed Formula Exchanges

- Contract Formula: If switching from one contract formula to another, benefits can be exchanged remotely (the endorser does not need to come to the clinic).
- Non-Contact/Exempt Formula: A completed *Physician Authorization Form* is required. Benefits can be exchanged remotely only if:
 - ✓ The new prescription has been received by the clinic, and
 - ✓ The WIC high risk counselor determines that the endorser does not need an in person visit for additional education or instructions on the use of the formula.

Redeemed Formula Exchanges

- Only unopened formula purchased in the current month may be exchanged.
- Unopened cans of formula must be returned to the clinic to be exchanged for the new requested formula. Compass calculates the amount that can be reissued based on the federal maximum allowable reconstituted ounces.
 - Before changing the food package, open the Foods branch and select “Returned Formula”.
Note: Formula from the current month can still be returned even if a new food package is issued.
 - Document the returned formula on the [Formula Disposal Log](#) and save it in the clinic’s central files for program monitoring.
- Select the “Get Balance” button. The returned formula grid will display a row of the current month’s formula issued to the participant.
- Enter the quantity of formula returned into the grid and save. Compass will not allow an amount greater than what was purchased with the eWIC card for the current month.
- Compass automatically calculates the amount of formula allowed to be reissued.

Compass Steps for Food and Formula Exchanges

- Go to the Foods branch and select “Food Package”. Click “new” to create a new food package.
- Select a new model food package from the drop-down list and save. Staff may also tailor the food package or create a new package “from scratch.”
- Verify the appropriate issuance period (1, 2, or 3 months).
- Once verified, click the “Issue Benefits” button. Compass will automatically calculate the remaining food benefits for the participant.
- Obtain the endorser’s signature acknowledging receipt of food benefits.
- Review the *Family Food Benefits* printout with the endorser or proxy.

Formula Disposal

- Formula returned by a participant must be disposed of and cannot be reused, shared, donated, or given to another WIC participant (ie, for trial or sample), including food banks or animal shelters.
- Returned formula must be destroyed within two (2) days of receipt.
- WIC staff must record the destroyed formula on the Formula Disposal Log and save the log in the clinic’s central files.

Formula Exchanges When Ordered from a Pharmacy



- Formula ordered from a pharmacy that has not been issued to a participant (never left the clinic) may be issued to another WIC participant. It may be transferred between WIC clinics in one of the following ways:
 1. Transferred by WIC Staff: The formula transfer must be approved by a supervisor or lead staff. The formula must be received the same day.
 2. Shipped: The formula must be received by the clinic well in advance of the formula's expiration date so that it may be used by the participant before it expires.

General Guidelines for Formula Exchanges

- Staff should never authorize the exchange of formula at a grocery store or pharmacy.
- Opened cans of formula cannot be exchanged.
- Stored formulas must be kept out of public view to avoid undermining breastfeeding promotion efforts.
- All formula exchanges must be documented in the participant's record.

Redeemed Formula Replacement

Redeemed formula issued during the current month can be replaced in certain individual emergencies. An individual emergency is a situation that affects one person or family; it is not a large-scale disaster or a presidentially or state-declared disaster. Examples of individual emergencies may include, but are not limited to:

- House fire.
- Flood.
- Theft.
- Fleeing domestic violence.
- Custody changes where the redeemed formula was not provided to the new caregivers.

To replace the redeemed formula, the client should provide proof of the emergency. Proof could include:

- A police report.
- A landlord statement (in the case of an apartment fire).
- A theft report from a store.
- A letter from a shelter (for domestic violence situations).
- A letter from a caseworker.
- If no formal proof is available, a signed statement from the participant or endorser is acceptable. The signed statement can be completed using the General Signature Document printed from Compass or as a written statement or provided in an email from the participant. It must include:
 - Number of cans that need to be replaced (current benefit month only).
 - Name of the formula.
 - Reason for the replacement.
 - The date.
 - The participant's signature (typed signature is acceptable if submitted by email).

Procedure: To replace the redeemed formula, WIC staff should:

1. Gather information about the request, including the formula name, benefit month, number of cans, and reason for the replacement.
2. Review the Rights and Responsibilities with the participant, emphasizing that WIC benefits are intended for the individual participant and cannot be sold or exchanged.
3. Scan the proof document or signed statement into the participant's Compass record.
4. Email the request and supporting documentation to cdphe.wicformula@state.co.us. State Office staff will issue the replacement and notify local agency staff once completed.

Additional Guidelines for Redeemed Formula Replacement:

- Local agencies must not return redeemed formulas in Compass for individual emergencies. All redeemed formula replacements for emergency situations are handled by the State Office.
- Redeemed formula can only be replaced once per participant in a 12-month period.